Day 4 Student Notes: Claude Desktop, Projects and Cowork

Claude for DevOps Mastery. Keep these notes and the prompts.

> **Goal of Day 4:** use what Pro adds. A **Project** keeps your files and rules. **Cowork** works on a folder and creates files for you.

Day 3 to Day 4

In the free chat, Claude only writes text. You paste everything and copy the answer out. With Pro and Claude Desktop, Claude keeps files in a Project and, with Cowork, can read a folder you connect and save new files in it. You still use RCTCF: Role, Context, Task, Constraints, Format.

What Pro gives you

Feature	Free	Pro
Chat	Yes	Yes, more usage
Projects	Yes (up to 5)	Yes, plus RAG for much more knowledge
Cowork	No	Yes
Claude Code (Day 5)	No	Yes
Usage limits	Lower	Higher. Session limit resets every 5 hours

Check the current price and plan details on claude.com/pricing. Plans and names change, so check there.

Claude Desktop

1. Go to claude.ai/download and choose your system.
2. Install it (Windows 10 or later, macOS 13 or later).
3. Open the app and sign in with the same account that has Pro.

Inside: **Chat**, **Projects**, **Cowork** and **Code** (Day 5). Anthropic is merging Cowork into the main Claude experience ("Cowork is now just Claude"). Your screen may show a Cowork option, or only one Claude. The idea is the same.

Chat, Project or Cowork?

	Plain chat	Project	Cowork
Best for	Quick question	Ongoing work with the same files and rules	A multi-step job that ends in files
Remembers	Only this chat	Project files and instructions	The folder you connect
DevOps example	Explain this error	Ask about our architecture notes	Build a page, change it, write the postmortem
Output	Text	Text based on your files	Text and new files

Projects

- **Project knowledge:** files you upload once. Claude uses them in every chat in the project.
- **Project instructions:** your RCTCF rules, written once.
- **RAG (paid plans):** with a lot of files, Claude searches them instead of loading them all, so a Project can hold much more.

What to upload

Good: architecture notes, config files with secrets removed, runbooks and checklists, old incident notes, team rules. **Never:** passwords, API keys, tokens, private keys, .env files, real customer data, or company files you are not allowed to share.

Hands-on comes after the Cowork section below.

Cowork

With free chat you paste the log and copy a text answer into a file. With Cowork you connect a folder, Claude reads the files, plans the steps, works through them and saves the result as a file. It shows its steps and you can redirect it.

Stay in control

- **Folder:** connect only an empty practice folder (for example Day4_Practice). Never your Desktop, Documents or a work folder.
- **Approvals:** keep **Manually approve** on. Claude must ask before deleting files. Do not choose Skip all approvals.
- **Usage:** big tasks use more of your limit than chat. Check Settings, then Usage.
- The output is a first draft. Check it against the files.

Hands-on: Claude builds and changes a page

You only do a few small things: make an **empty** folder (for example Day4_Practice), connect it to Claude Desktop, paste the prompts, and open index.html in your browser. Claude does the rest.

Step 1: Claude builds a status page

```
Role: You are a friendly DevOps trainer.
Context: A class demo. A made-up online shop called ShopEasy. No real data.
Task: Create one file, index.html, that works when double-clicked. It is a status
page: a title, a green banner "All systems working", and 5 service cards (Website,
Checkout, Database, Cache, Payments). Each card is green, says "Working" and shows
a response time in ms.
Constraints: One file only. No internet and no outside libraries. Do not touch
other files.
Format: Clean, simple, big text that is easy to read from the back of a room.
```

Claude shows its plan and asks permission. Approve, then double-click **index.html** in the folder. It opens in your browser. Keep the tab open.

Step 2: change it in plain English

```
Change index.html. Make Database red and say "Down: 20 of 20 connections used".
Make Checkout amber and say "Slow". Change the banner to red: "Checkout is
failing". Add an "Incident timeline" section with 4 made-up steps.
```

Refresh the browser tab. The Database card turns red and the banner changes.

Step 3: fix it and write it up

```
The incident is fixed. Update index.html: all services green, banner "All systems
working", and add a last timeline step "Rolled back, normal again". Then write
postmortem.md from the timeline on the page. Do not invent facts. Write "unknown"
where the page is silent.
```

Check: Refresh: all green again. Open postmortem.md. Did Claude invent anything? Did it write "unknown" where the page is silent? Did it leave other files alone?

Step 4: a Project in 2 minutes

1. Open **Projects**, choose **New project**, name it **DevOps Assistant**.
2. Add **index.html** and **postmortem.md**.
3. Paste these into the project instructions:

```
Role: You are a friendly senior DevOps mentor.
Context: I am learning DevOps. This project holds notes and files about a practice
shop called ShopEasy.
Task: Answer my questions using the project files.
Constraints: If the answer is not in the files, say so. Do not guess. Never ask me
for passwords.
Format: Short answers. Use bullet points. Name the file you used.
```

Then ask: "What caused the incident? Which file did you use?" A good answer names the file. Test it with "What is the Redis password?": a good answer says it is not in the files.

Which one would you use?

Situation	Pick
"What does CrashLoopBackOff mean?"	Plain chat
Many questions about the same architecture notes	Project
Turn a folder of incident notes into one summary file	Cowork
Fix and test code inside a Git repository	Claude Code (Day 5)

Ask yourself: one question, ongoing context, or a job with files?

Key words

Word	Meaning
Project	A workspace that keeps files and instructions for many chats
Project knowledge	The files you add to a Project
Project instructions	Rules Claude follows in every chat of the Project
RAG	Claude searches your files instead of loading them all, so a Project can hold more
Cowork	Claude works through a multi-step job in a folder you connect and creates files
Runbook	Step-by-step guide for handling a problem
Postmortem	A write-up after an incident: what happened, why, and what to change

Check yourself

1. Name two things a Project keeps for you.
2. Why connect only a practice folder to Cowork?
3. What should a good Project answer do when the answer is not in the files?
4. Plain chat, Project or Cowork: build a page, change it and write a postmortem?
5. Name two things you must never upload.

Answers

1. Files (knowledge) and instructions.
2. Cowork can read and create files in the folder, so keep it away from real or private files.
3. Say it is not in the files and not guess.
4. Cowork.
5. Any two of: passwords, API keys, tokens, private keys, .env files, real customer data.

Take-home task (20 to 30 minutes)

1. In a new empty folder, ask Claude (Cowork) to build a status page for your own made-up app.
2. Change it twice in plain English (for example make one service red, then fix it) and refresh the browser each time.
3. Bring one screenshot to Day 5. No passwords, secrets or company data.

> **Before Day 5:** nothing to install. Claude Code comes with your Pro plan and we set it up together in class. If you already use Git or VS Code, keep them ready.